One Small Boat

By Kathy Harrison

KATHY: **(Pg 15-16)** I am fascinated by the myriad ways traumatized children learn to cope within a world that makes no sense. What looks like crazy can be the sanest thing imaginable when you know how a child has lived. I took care of kids with broken bones and cigarette burns. My children had police records and venereal disease. But my kids had other things. I have known young children willing to sacrifice their own safety in order to protect younger brothers and sisters. It made me glad every day that I had found the courage for the gritty reality of foster parenting.

INTRODUCTION

Daisy was five when she first entered Harrison's bustling household. Mother of three children by birth, three by adoption and a handful of foster kids always coming and going, Harrison had ten children under her roof at any given time. But Daisy was unique. Daisy's birth mother wasn't poor, uneducated, or drug addicted. She just could not take care of a child, and the effects of this abandonment on Daisy were heart-wrenching. Fear and anxiety marked her every move. After two weeks in Kathy's loving home, however, Daisy began to thrive. One Small Boat by Kathy Harrison.

SOCIAL WORKER: **(PG 18-25)** . . . Anyway, Tiffany is adorable. She has no special needs and no medical issues. I also have 10-year-old Carmen Santiago. Her mom just got sentenced to three months in jail. Carmen has hearing aids, but no other special needs. Then I've got Daisy, but I think we may need to find a hotline bed for her this weekend and look for a specialized slot next week.

KATHY: Why? What's up with her?

SOCIAL WORKER: Only six but two prior psych hospitalizations. Anorexic. Aggressive toward her mother. Very little speech. Maybe retarded. Very depressed. She's on a ton of medication.

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KATHY: *(to audience)* The handwriting was on the wall for Daisy. She was headed for a residential treatment program somewhere.

SOCIAL WORKER: Hey! Are you still there?

KATHY: Sorry. *(Chuckle)* I'm just thinking. Tiffany and Carmen sound like they'll be easy to place, so I guess I'd like to take Daisy. *(to audience)* When Daisy arrived on Saturday afternoon, she didn't walk in the front door. She scuttled. Like a small crab, she sidled away from me, making only brief eye contact and refusing to respond. She flitted from one piece of furniture, one toy, one book to the next, examining each only briefly before moving on. Nothing held her attention for more than a moment until she spied our cat, Molly.

DAISY: *(squealing and grabbing the cat, clutching her too tightly around the stomach)*

KATHY: Molly struggled to get loose, but Daisy seemed oblivious of the cat's discomfort. *(To Daisy, coming down to her level)* Molly doesn't like to be held so tightly, honey. It hurts her. Put her down and pet her gently. Like this. *(To audience and in pantomime)* Daisy let me take Molly from her and even let me run her hand gently over the cat's rumpled fur. *(To Daisy)* There you go. Molly will like you if you're kind to her. *(to audience)* I took the few minutes that Daisy spent stroking Molly to get a better look at her. What struck me was how unwell she looked. Her dark hair was so thin and wispy that in places her scalp showed through. There was not an ounce of fat on her emaciated body. Thin ribbons of green mucus ran from her nose. Dark eyes were sunk deep in her skull.

SOCIAL WORKER: I'm sorry to do this to you, Kathy. Do you think you can get through the weekend?

KATHY: That shouldn't be a problem. She looks too sick to be dangerous. What the heck is going on with this kid? I know she has some food issues, and I was told she doesn't talk. I suppose she's been checked out medically.

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SOCIAL WORK: Every test known to man. We have a long list of what she doesn't have, but no idea about what she does have, besides a laundry list of psychiatric problems: ADHD, Multiple phobias, Oppositional defiant disorder. Daisy's mom, Glenna, gave me the meds and a schedule of when they need to be given.

KATHY: The directions were filled with qualifiers like, "If she'll take it," "If she seems to need it. *(To Social Worker)* I can't do this, Evelyn. It's not safe. It looks like she hasn't had any of this stuff consistently for the last couple of weeks. *(To audience)* Medicating children for what often seems like pretty good adaptive responses to a crummy home life annoys me. Shouldn't calm and predictable reactions to challenging behavior be the first line of treatment for an oppositional kid, or is it just easier on everyone to slip him a pill? . . . **(pg 27-30)** I was glad to have Evelyn leave so I could return to Daisy. . . I took both of her thin hands in mine. *(To Daisy)* Your nose is running, hon. Let's wash your face, Okay? *(to audience)* I led Daisy to the bathroom and gently cleaned her face with a soft washcloth. Daisy flinched when I got near her face, a small movement that made me cringe. I knelt down to look at her and held up a hand mirror so she could see herself. Daisy looked at her image for a long time and then smiled. *(To Daisy)* You look so pretty, Daisy. Let's put some tissue in your pocket. When your nose runs, you can wipe it with that instead of your hand. Okay? *(to audience)* Daisy nodded. She started to spin and flap her hands. I stood behind her, wrapped my arms around her bony frame, and whispered in her ear. *(To Daisy)* Take a deep breath, sweetie. Hey, did you know that I have the best job in the whole world? My job is to keep kids safe. I get to make sure things aren't so scary. Bad things won't happen to you here. Okay?

TRANSITION

And things progressed nicely for a few days . . . until Daisy's mother, Glenna requested a home visit to see if our house met her standards.

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GLENNA: **(Pg 43-46)** Oh, my God, I am so happy to meet you. You must be a saint or something, taking in a kid like Daisy.

KATHY: I had done my best to spiff [Daisy] up for the occasion. She was nicely dressed and her nose was wiped. It had taken a couple of days for Daisy's psychiatrist to get back to me, and by that time it was pretty clear that Daisy could function without medication. While I couldn't be sure that was the whole reason, Daisy looked less spacey than she had when she arrived. I think I held some hope that Glenna would see Daisy differently and consider taking her only child home. She took some effort, especially around meals, but I had rarely seen a child as anxious to please as this one. I hated to see Daisy go, but I just couldn't come up with a reasons for her to be in foster care. I called her down. [Daisy . . . Daisy . . . can you come downstairs for a minute, please]

DAISY: *[hopping into the living room, then stops dead when she sees her mother; a stricken look on her face]*

GLENNA: *[recited as if she has practiced this in front of a mirror]* Daisy! Baby! I've missed you. Come give Mommy a hug.

DAISY: *[a worried expression on her face]* Hi, Mommy. You comin to get me? I goin home? *[slowly begin to rock and flap her hands, whispering a count of one to ten]*

KATHY: **(Pg 47-51)** Daisy began a pattern I was beginning to recognize, rocking rapidly back and forth, flapping her hands, and chanting from one to ten, over and over, all in a futile effort to wrest some control from her chaotic world.

EVELYN: Why don't you have Kathy and Daisy show you her room, Glenna?

KATHY: Her eyes widened when she saw four beds in Daisy's room.

GLENNA: Daisy's used to having her own space. I'm not sure she should be sharing with other kids. Is there any way that could happen?

KATHY: *[evenly]* I'm afraid not, Glenna. Kids lose a lot when they come into foster care. Not just their families but their houses and schools and pets and friends. It's

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hard on kids, but most of them adapt to the physical changes pretty quickly. Daisy is doing just fine. *(to audience)* Emotionally, this little girl had been hit by a truck, and the best her mother could come up with was to worry about her accommodations. . . Daisy fell apart. It wasn't a gradual fall. It was a dramatic crash.

DAISY: *[flapping and spinning at a rapid rate, pulling on her mother, yapping like a small puppy]*

KATHY: For the first time since her arrival, I saw the hyperactivity and bizarre behavior that had been reported. The wilder Daisy got, the more anxious Glenna became.

GLENNA: *[pleading]* (*NOTE – The following words are not in the text . . . Daisy, baby, settle down now . . . please, Daisy.)

KATHY: The hesitancy and uncertainty in her voice was not lost on Daisy, who responded with a maniacal laugh. *(Daisy laughs)* I was reluctant to intervene, and I might not have had Daisy not begun pounding on Glenna's back. It needed to stop. *(in pantomime and in words)* I caught Daisy from behind, wrapping my arms around her thing frame and dropping to the floor. *(To Daisy firmly)* Daisy, you need to stop. Can you do that by yourself, or do you need me to help you?

DAISY: *(breath coming in quick, shallow gulps, panicked she speaks softly)* Help.

KATHY: All right. I want you to take some deep breaths like I showed you. When you calm down, I want you to get the clay out of the art box. I want you to sit at the table and play with it until I come. Can you do that? *(to audience)* After a moment, Daisy nodded. I relaxed my grip and helped her up. She didn't attempt to speak to her mother, but did as I asked, defeated.

EVELYN: Is, uh, that pretty typical behavior for Daisy?

GLENNA: Pretty much. Sometimes it's a lot worse. You can see why I can't take care of her. She just get out of control, and I don't know what to do with her. I

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thought the hospital would help, but they seemed to think everything was my fault. Like making me take a parenting class is going to change Daisy.

TRANSITION – a few months pass

KATHY: **(Pg 92-93)** What's up, sweetie? Are you okay?

DAISY: I okay. Is I going home soon?

KATHY: I don't know, Daisy, do you want to go home?

DAISY: I miss my mom sometimes, but I be a bad girl at her house. That's why her don't like me. She thinks I weird.

KATHY: Sometimes grown-ups have so many of their own worries to think about that they don't have a lot left over to give to other people, even their own kids. I know your mom cares about you. I think she wants you to be happy, but she doesn't know how to help you. *(Phone rings and Kathy answers)* **(Pg 138-139)**

EVELYN: Hey, Kathy, it's Evelyn. Are you sitting down? Glenna just called. She is rescinding the voluntary. She would like to have Daisy packed and ready to leave on Friday.

KATHY: Can she do that? Just call and say she wants her back?

EVELYN: It's been voluntary all along, Kathy. She can do anything she wants.

KATHY: Did I do something? Isn't she happy with Daisy's care?

EVELYN: Actually, I think she may be too happy with Daisy's care. I think she would be happier if Daisy seemed a little more homesick. You're a tough act to follow for a mother who isn't exactly June Cleaver.

KATHY: Give me a break. So this is it. She's done being overwhelmed and wants to be a mommy again, and we say good-bye and you bring me another kid.

EVELYN: That's kind of the way it works, Kathy. This is foster care. Isn't supposed to last forever because you fall in love with a kid.

KATHY: *(to audience)* Of course she needed to go home. It really should have happened a long time ago. Daisy had been with us for seven months.

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EVELYN: Life goes on. There will be another kid, Kathy.

KATHY: There won't be another Daisy . . . **(Pg 143-150)** Evelyn was right, of course. Life did go on, but the grief didn't go away. If anything, it got worse, intensified because I had no way to check on Daisy. Two weeks went by without a word from Glenna. I called a few times, but always got the machine and my messages went unanswered. Let it go, I reminded myself over and over. You gave her what you had to give and it's time to move on . . . and then [my phone] rang in the parking lot of the supermarket. *(answering)* Hello?

BRUCE: Are you coming right home after shopping?

KATHY: Is something wrong?

BRUCE: I guess that depends on your perspective. I got a call from the hotline. They just picked Daisy up at the hospital. They want to know if we'll take her.

KATHY: What happened?

BRUCE: Her mom brought her into the emergency room. She said Daisy was out of control. I guess Daisy was hitting Glenna and climbing all over the furniture, like a madwoman.

KATHY: How did Glenna get her to the hospital?

BRUCE: In an ambulance, if you can believe it.

KATHY: *(To audience)* My poor Daisy, afraid of both hospitals and sirens. Fear alone would have made her look crazy by the time she got to the emergency room. . . What was I expecting when I heard the car pull into the driveway? I expected to see what I was feeling – disorganized, confused, fearful. The car had barely stopped before Daisy was out. She didn't just run up the driveway. She flew, straight into my arms. *(To Daisy)* Hey, kiddo! Welcome home! I have been missing you!

DAISY: Why didn't you never call me? You said you would. My mom said you were too busy with new kids to call me.

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KATHY: *(to audience)* She looked terrible. She looked nearly as bad as she had when she arrived the previous winter. *(To Daisy)* Was I ever too busy for you, Daisy. *(to audience)* People wonder, I know. They think I must be crazy to choose to spend my days with kids like these: kids who smell bad and eat with their hands and tell us things we would rather not know. But I have moment like this and then I remember why I'm here. **(Pg 152-153)** *(to Daisy)* Pretty rough day, huh, Daisy? Do you want to talk about it?

DAISY: My mommy got very, very mad at me. She yelled at me and called the peoples to take me away.

KATHY: Any idea why she was so mad?

DAISY: Cause I hitted her with my slipper

KATHY: You must have been pretty mad. What do you think made you so mad at your mom? *(To audience)* The pause that followed my question was so long that I though Daisy was not going to answer.

DAISY: *(taking a deep breath)* He hurted me, you know. He hurted me every day, and she never told him to stop. Why didn't she never come when I called her.

KATHY: *(to audience)* I assumed Daisy was talking about her mom's old boyfriend, Frank. *(to Daisy)* Your mommy was home when Frank hurt you?

DAISY: I think she home.

KATHY: It must have made you pretty mad when that was happening, Daisy. I bet I would have felt like hitting her, too. But I think you may be wrong about this. I think your mom didn't know what Frank was doing. As soon as she knew, she made him leave. And she sent you here so you would be safe. *(to audience)* Please, God, let me be right about that. Let it be true that she really didn't know. Daisy and I talked for a while longer. She gave me details I didn't want to know. It took every ounce of self-control I could muster to listen and respond without letting the disgust I felt come through . . . **(Pg 171)** Sexual abuse is a terrible thing to

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happen to a child. It is far worse than a beating. It brings with it shame as well as violation, and I know of few children able to believe they are not somehow at fault.

DAISY: **(pg 193)** Sometimes . . . Sometimes I wish you was my mom and I never had to move. I just want this to be home.

KATHY: **(pg 200)** This is a crazy life. **(pg xviii)** Every day more than seven hundred children come into care because of suspected abuse or neglect. One-third will never go home to their original families again. One-third who do go home will be back in care again before they reach adulthood. There are more than 550,000 children in the child welfare system in this country. Its enormity excuses our tendency to forget that these are not numbers but real little people. Little people who **(page 200-201)** tell me things that are so sad and so awful I can digest only small pieces at a time . . . [but] Sometimes there are really good days. Sometimes a mother will show up for a visit, and I can feel the love between her and this kid. She's clean and sober, and she's finished her parenting course. She's getting her daughter back, and I feel like I had a small part in this wonderful thing. This is fostering life. **(pg xix)** Daisy? Daisy was a teacher. She taught me about strength and courage and resiliency. I also learned about loving and losing and that happy endings are often what we make for ourselves.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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